ROADMAP FOR ROMANIA

TO JOIN THE

EUROPEAN MOLECULAR BIOLOGY LABORATORY

(EMBL)

A Comprehensive 4-Year Strategic Plan

From National Preparation to Full Membership

2026 – 2030

Prepared for:

Ministry of Research, Innovation and Digitalization

Ministry of Foreign Affairs

Ministry of Finance

Romanian Academy · National Research Community

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1. Executive Summary

This document presents a comprehensive strategic plan for Romania to achieve full membership in the European Molecular Biology Laboratory (EMBL) within a 4-year horizon (2026–2030). EMBL, established in 1974, is the leading intergovernmental organization in Europe for molecular biology research, currently supported by 29 full member states, one associate member state, and two prospect member states (Serbia and Bulgaria).

Romania is not currently a member of EMBL, nor of the European Molecular Biology Conference (EMBC), the intergovernmental conference that funds the European Molecular Biology Organization (EMBO) and underpins EMBL. Romania's absence from these structures represents a significant gap in its European research integration, particularly in the life sciences, genomics, bioinformatics, and biotechnology.

The plan proposes a phased approach through EMBL's Prospect Membership mechanism — a three-year trial period during which Romania would gain observer status on the EMBL Council and full access to EMBL services, training, PhD and postdoctoral programmes, research facilities, and professional networks, without paying the full membership contribution. Romania has a recent precedent in European life-science integration: it became an ELIXIR Observer in October 2023.

Core recommendation: Romania should adopt a government-level decision in principle to pursue EMBL Prospect Membership by late 2026, sign a Statement of Intent in 2027, complete the three-year prospect period by 2030, and transition to full membership with phased financial contributions.

Estimated annual cost at full membership: Approximately €2–3 million per year (based on Romania's share of EU GDP and comparison with similar-sized member states). During the prospect period, no membership fee is required.

2. Background and Context

2.1. What Is EMBL?

The European Molecular Biology Laboratory is an intergovernmental research organization dedicated to molecular biology, bioinformatics, structural biology, imaging, and related fields. It was created in 1974 by ten founding countries and now operates from six sites: the main laboratory in Heidelberg (Germany), and sites in Barcelona (Spain), Grenoble (France), Hamburg (Germany), Hinxton near Cambridge (the European Bioinformatics Institute, EMBL-EBI, in England), and Rome (Italy).

EMBL conducts fundamental research, provides services to researchers across its member states, trains the next generation of scientists through its flagship International PhD Programme and postdoctoral fellowships, drives innovation and technology transfer, and acts as an integrator of European life sciences. Its annual budget is approximately DKK 1.85 billion (~€250 million), of which roughly one quarter comes from member state contributions and the remainder from external sources.

2.2. What Is EMBC?

The European Molecular Biology Conference (EMBC), founded in 1969, is a separate intergovernmental organization comprising 32 member states. It funds the European Molecular Biology Organization (EMBO), which runs fellowship programmes, training courses, workshops, and the Young Investigator Programme. EMBC membership gives a country's researchers access to EMBO fellowships (short-term, long-term, postdoctoral, installation grants) and scientific meetings.

EMBC and EMBL are legally distinct but deeply interconnected. The EMBL Establishing Agreement provides that EMBC member states may accede to EMBL. In practice, countries joining EMBL are expected to also be EMBC members by the time they complete the prospect period.

Romania is not a member of EMBC. The 32 current EMBC member states include most EU countries, including all of Romania's neighbours (Bulgaria, Hungary) and comparators (Poland, Czech Republic, Slovakia, Croatia, Slovenia), but not Romania.

2.3. Romania's Current Position

Romania currently participates in no EMBL or EMBC structure. Its only formal engagement with the broader EMBL ecosystem is through ELIXIR — the European life-sciences infrastructure for bioinformatics — where Romania joined as an Observer in October 2023. The Romanian ELIXIR Node is centred around the Romanian Society for Bioinformatics (RSBI) and the Romanian Bioinformatics Cluster (CRB), a consortium of 17 universities and research centres. Romania is also a partner in the ELIXIR-STEERS Horizon Europe project.

Romania's absence from EMBL and EMBC means that Romanian researchers currently lack formal, institutional access to EMBL's training, infrastructure, PhD programme, imaging centre, data resources, and the full suite of EMBO fellowship and mobility programmes that their counterparts in 32 other European countries enjoy.

2.4. Why Now?

Several converging factors make this the right moment for Romania to pursue EMBL membership:

- Recent precedent: Serbia signed its Statement of Intent in 2023 and Bulgaria followed in 2024, both becoming prospect members with immediate effect. The accession process is active and proven.

- ELIXIR momentum: Romania's 2023 ELIXIR Observer status provides existing institutional machinery, stakeholder networks, and political precedent that can be leveraged for EMBL/EMBC accession.
- EU strategic priorities: Life sciences, genomics, AI for biology, and health innovation are named EU competitiveness priorities, with significant Horizon Europe and national RDI funding aligned.
- Peer country action: All of Romania's EU neighbours (Bulgaria, Hungary, Poland, Czech Republic, Slovakia, Croatia, Slovenia) are already EMBL and/or EMBC members. Romania's absence is increasingly anomalous.
- Talent retention: Romania faces significant brain drain in the sciences. EMBL membership creates structured mobility pathways and institutional linkages that can help retain and circulate top talent.

3. The EMBL Accession Pathway

3.1. Legal and Institutional Framework

EMBL is governed by the Agreement Establishing the European Molecular Biology Laboratory (1974, as amended). The Agreement provides that any State which is a member of EMBC may accede to EMBL by depositing an instrument of accession with the Swiss government (the depositary). The EMBL Council, which meets twice yearly, decides on membership matters by majority vote.

In addition to the treaty-based full membership route, EMBL has developed a Prospect Membership mechanism. Under this arrangement, a state commits to accede to EMBL after three years and during that period gains access to the laboratory's services and programmes, as well as observer status in the EMBL Council (up to two delegates, one governmental and one scientific, with voice but no vote).

3.2. Prospect Membership: The Three-Year Trial Period

Prospect Membership is the recommended entry point for new member states. During the three-year prospect period:

- The prospect member's researchers gain full access to EMBL facilities, services, training programmes, PhD and postdoctoral opportunities.
- The prospect member designates two Council observers (one from a relevant ministry, one scientific advisor).
- No membership contribution is due during the prospect period.
- Nine months before the prospect period ends, the state must confirm its intent to accede to full membership.
- Upon full accession, financial contributions are phased in, typically starting at approximately 30% of the full rate in year one of membership, rising to 100% by approximately the fifth year.

3.3. The EMBC Parallel Track

While EMBL prospect membership can be initiated before EMBC membership, the EMBL framework expects that a prospect member will join EMBC by the end of the prospect period. EMBC accession involves ratifying the EMBC Agreement, which typically requires cabinet/government approval and, in many countries, parliamentary action.

For Romania, EMBC membership should be pursued in parallel with EMBL prospect membership. EMBC membership brings its own significant benefits — principally access to EMBO fellowship programmes, installation grants (which support early-career researchers returning to their home country), courses, and workshops.

3.4. Recent Accession Case Studies

Country	Prospect Start	Full Member	Key Feature	Key Activities During Prospect
Estonia	2019	Feb 2023	Small country	MoU with Univ. of Tartu; delegation visits; workshops

Latvia	2020	Nov 2024	Strong bioinformatics	Latvian Bioinformatics Forum; MoU with BMC Riga; EMBL Info Day; TREC visit
Lithuania	2016	2019	Early mover in Baltics	Built national engagement; joined EMBC in parallel
Serbia	Jun 2023	Expected 2026	Non-EU, strong intent	Minister signed SoI; EMBL-EBI visit; Belgrade meetings; Council delegation
Bulgaria	Jul 2024	Expected 2027	Academy + Ministry lead	Academy institute + Ministry expert as delegates; co-led by BAS

These examples demonstrate that 3–4 years from formal intent to full membership is realistic and repeatable. The pattern involves: (a) high-level political commitment, (b) designation of qualified delegates, (c) national scientific outreach activities, (d) at least one institutional MoU or partnership, and (e) parallel EMBC accession.

4. Strategic Rationale for Romania

4.1. Scientific and Technological Value

EMBL membership provides direct access to cutting-edge research infrastructure, including the EMBL Imaging Centre (cryo-EM, super-resolution and intravital microscopy), structural biology beamlines at EMBL Hamburg and EMBL Grenoble, the world's leading bioinformatics data resources at EMBL-EBI, advanced sequencing services, and proteomics and metabolomics facilities. Romanian researchers in molecular biology, genomics, structural biology, imaging, bioinformatics, computational biology, and related fields would benefit directly.

4.2. Training and Human Capital

EMBL's International PhD Programme is one of the most competitive and prestigious doctoral programmes in the life sciences globally. PhD students at EMBL are registered with partner universities (including the University of Cambridge for EMBL-EBI) and receive world-class training. EMBL's postdoctoral programme (EIPOD-LinC) supports interdisciplinary research with partner institutions in member states. EMBL also runs an extensive programme of advanced training courses and conferences.

For Romania, this means structured pathways for the country's best young scientists to receive top-tier training while maintaining institutional linkages back to Romania — something that ad hoc brain drain does not provide.

4.3. Integration into the European Research Area

EMBL membership signals serious commitment to European research integration. It places Romania at the table for decisions about European life-science strategy, infrastructure priorities, and resource allocation. It opens doors for collaborative projects, joint grants, and institutional partnerships that are structurally unavailable to non-members.

4.4. Biotechnology and Innovation

EMBL has an active technology transfer and innovation programme. Its spin-off companies, patent portfolio, and industry partnerships generate significant economic value. Member state researchers and institutions benefit from proximity to this innovation ecosystem. For Romania's emerging biotech sector, this could be a meaningful accelerator.

4.5. National Competitiveness

Romania is currently the only large EU member state (population >15 million) not in either EMBL or EMBC. All neighbouring countries are members. This absence is increasingly visible and increasingly costly in terms of missed opportunities, missed training slots, missed collaborations, and missed talent circulation.

5. Detailed Four-Year Implementation Plan (2026–2030)

5.1. Year 1 (2026): National Preparation and Decision in Principle

5.1.1. Government Decision in Principle (Q1–Q2 2026)

Obtain a formal decision from the competent authority (Ministry of Research, Innovation and Digitalization, or equivalent) supporting Romania's pursuit of EMBL Prospect Membership. This should take the form of a government memorandum or ministerial order, modeled on the precedent set by Romania's ELIXIR accession (where a government-level memorandum approved participation and a membership request).

Required actions:

- Draft a ministerial memorandum (see Annex A for template).
- Obtain inter-ministerial clearance (Research, Foreign Affairs, Finance).
- Secure cabinet or government-level endorsement.

5.1.2. Establish the National Working Group (Q2 2026)

Create an inter-institutional working group with the mandate to prepare Romania's EMBL accession. The working group should be chaired by the ministry responsible for research and include representatives from:

- Ministry of Research, Innovation and Digitalization (lead authority)
- Ministry of Foreign Affairs (treaty/accession logistics)
- Ministry of Finance (budgetary assessment)
- Romanian Academy (scientific legitimacy and coordination)
- Major research universities: University of Bucharest, Alexandru Ioan Cuza University of Iași, Babeș-Bolyai University of Cluj-Napoca, University of Medicine and Pharmacy Carol Davila (Bucharest), University of Medicine, Pharmacy, Science and Technology G.E. Palade of Târgu Mureș, Politehnica University of Bucharest, Technical University of Cluj-Napoca
- National R&D institutes active in biology, medicine, genomics: Victor Babeș National Institute of Pathology, Cantacuzino National Institute, National Institute of Genetics, Institute of Biochemistry of the Romanian Academy
- Romanian Bioinformatics Cluster (CRB) and Romanian Society for Bioinformatics (RSBI)
- Hospital-based research leaders (e.g., oncology, genomics, rare diseases)
- Representatives of Romania's biotech/pharma sector

5.1.3. Demand Mapping Exercise (Q2–Q3 2026)

The working group should conduct a systematic assessment of national demand, answering the following questions:

- Which Romanian laboratories and institutions would use EMBL-linked opportunities?
- In which fields is demand strongest (genomics, bioinformatics, structural biology, imaging, computational biology, molecular medicine)?
- How many doctoral candidates, postdoctoral researchers, and principal investigators would realistically apply to EMBL programmes annually?

- What EMBL services (imaging, sequencing, data resources, structural biology beamlines) are most relevant?
- What existing collaborations with EMBL or EMBL alumni already exist?
- What co-benefits would accrue for health research, biotech innovation, and AI-for-biology capacity?

> *Practical tool: A short online survey distributed to all Romanian universities, Academy institutes, and medical research centres, collecting: (a) current life-science research areas, (b) existing EMBL/EMBO contacts, (c) interest in EMBL programmes, (d) expected annual applications. See Annex C for a template questionnaire.*

5.1.4. Cost-Benefit Analysis (Q3–Q4 2026)

Prepare a budgetary assessment. Key data points:

Comparator Country	Approx. Share of EU GDP	Estimated Annual EMBL Contribution
Hungary	~1.0%	~€1.05 million
Greece	~1.3%	~€1.4–1.5 million
Portugal	~1.6%	~€1.6 million
Poland	~3.7%	~€4.5 million
Romania (estimated)	~1.9%	~€2–3 million

During the three-year prospect period, no membership fee is payable. Upon full accession, contributions are phased: approximately 30% in the first year, rising incrementally to 100% by approximately the fifth year of membership. One-time accession fees have historically been modest (e.g., €45,000 for Estonia, €106,000 for Latvia in 2024).

5.1.5. Informal EMBL Engagement (Q3–Q4 2026)

Begin informal engagement with EMBL's International Relations team:

- Request an exploratory meeting (virtual or at EMBL Heidelberg).
- Invite EMBL representatives to a Romanian scientific event.
- Plan and execute a Romanian delegation visit to an EMBL site (Heidelberg or EMBL-EBI Hinxton are recommended).
- Explore the possibility of an EMBL Information Day in Romania (a format EMBL has used successfully in Latvia and other prospect countries).

5.1.6. Begin EMBC Accession Process (Q3–Q4 2026)

In parallel, initiate the legal and diplomatic steps for Romania to join EMBC. This typically requires:

- Government decision to seek EMBC membership.
- Contact with the EMBC Secretariat (housed at EMBO in Heidelberg).
- Cabinet/government approval of the EMBC Agreement ratification.
- Parliamentary action if required under Romanian constitutional law.
- Deposit of the ratification instrument.

Latvia's EMBC accession in November 2023 provides a recent precedent: cabinet approval was completed in October, followed by unanimous approval by the EMBC itself upon presentation by the Latvian delegation.

5.2. Year 2 (2027): Formal Prospect Membership

5.2.1. Sign Statement of Intent (Q1–Q2 2027)

A high-level Romanian official — ideally the Minister of Research or equivalent — formally signs the Statement of Intent with EMBL. This may occur at or adjacent to an EMBL Council meeting. Serbia's Minister of Science signed the SoI directly; Bulgaria's Minister of Education and Science supported the accession announcement.

Required document: A formal Statement of Intent from the Romanian Government (see Annex B for template language).

5.2.2. EMBL Council Vote

The EMBL Council votes (by majority) to admit Romania as a Prospect Member State. This is typically a procedural step once the SoI is received.

5.2.3. Designate National Delegates

Romania designates two delegates to attend EMBL Council as observers:

- **Governmental delegate:** A senior official from the Ministry of Research or equivalent (Director, Secretary of State, or Department Head level).
- **Scientific delegate:** A prominent Romanian scientist with expertise in molecular biology, genomics, bioinformatics, or a related field. This person should ideally be a recognized research leader (professor, institute director, or Academy member).

> *Role model: Bulgaria designated Stoyno Stoynov (Deputy Director and Group Leader, Institute of Molecular Biology, Bulgarian Academy of Sciences) and Mikaela Stancheva (Expert, Science Directorate, Ministry of Education and Science). Latvia designated Jānis Kloviņš (Professor of Molecular Biology, University of Latvia, and BMC research council head) alongside its Ministry of Education and Science.*

5.2.4. National Outreach Activities

During Year 2, Romania should execute a structured national outreach programme:

1. **Romanian Life Sciences Forum:** Organize a one-day national forum, co-organized with EMBL, bringing together Romanian researchers in molecular biology, genomics, bioinformatics, computational biology, imaging, and related fields. Model: the Latvian Bioinformatics Forum (July 2022), co-organized by BMC Riga, University of Latvia, Riga Technical University, and EMBL.
2. **Institutional MoU:** Sign a Memorandum of Understanding between EMBL and a leading Romanian institution (e.g., a major medical university, the Romanian Academy's Institute of Biochemistry, or the CRB). Model: EMBL-BMC Latvia MoU (2022), EMBL-University of Tartu MoU (Estonia).
3. **EMBL Information Day in Romania:** Invite EMBL researchers and programme managers to present EMBL services, PhD/postdoc opportunities, and collaboration possibilities to the Romanian scientific community. Model: EMBL Information Day in Latvia (September 2023).
4. **Reciprocal visits:** Send Romanian delegation(s) to EMBL sites; host EMBL representatives at Romanian events.

5.2.5. Public Communication

Issue a press release and ministerial statement announcing Romania's EMBL Prospect Membership, emphasizing benefits for health research, biotechnology, education, and national competitiveness.

5.3. Years 3–4 (2028–2029): Prospect Period — Integration and Demonstration

5.3.1. Active Engagement with EMBL Programmes

Romanian researchers should actively apply to:

- EMBL International PhD Programme (both winter and summer recruitment rounds).
- EIPOD-LinC postdoctoral programme (which requires a member state partner institution).
- EMBL advanced training courses and conferences at the Heidelberg Advanced Training Centre.
- EMBL Imaging Centre services (cryo-EM, super-resolution microscopy).
- EMBL-EBI data resources, bioinformatics tools, and collaboration opportunities.
- EMBL structural biology beamlines and services at Hamburg and Grenoble.

5.3.2. Annual Progress Reports

The working group should produce annual evaluation reports tracking concrete metrics:

Metric	Target by End of Prospect Period
Romanian applicants to EMBL PhD programme	10–20 per recruitment round
Romanian PhDs enrolled at EMBL	2–4 active at any time
Romanian postdocs at EMBL or in EIPOD-LinC	1–3 active
Romanian participants in EMBL courses/conferences	20–40 annually
Romanian users of EMBL Imaging Centre/services	5–15 annually
Institutional MoUs or partnerships signed	2–3 during prospect period
Joint publications involving EMBL and Romanian authors	5–10 during prospect period
National forums/events co-organized with EMBL	2–3 during prospect period
EMBC fellowship recipients from Romania	5–10 annually (EMBO short/long-term)
EMBO Installation Grant applications from Romania	1–2 annually

5.3.3. Continued National Events

Continue the annual Romanian Life Sciences Forum, expand to include themed workshops (e.g., genomics data infrastructure, AI for biology, structural biology). Explore whether EMBL's TREC expedition (Traversing European Coastlines) could include a Romanian sampling stop — as it did in Latvia in 2023.

5.3.4. Complete EMBC Accession

If not completed in Year 1–2, finalize EMBC ratification and accession during this period. This is a prerequisite for full EMBL membership. Ensure parliamentary approval if required, deposit of ratification instrument, and designation of EMBC delegates.

5.3.5. Budget Planning for Full Membership

During the prospect period, the Ministry of Finance should include a provisional EMBL membership line in the forward RDI budget estimates, ramping from zero during prospect years to the phased contribution schedule upon accession. This avoids a fiscal surprise at the transition point.

5.4. Year 4 (2030): Decision on Full Membership and Accession

5.4.1. Formal Decision (Q1 2030)

Nine months before the prospect period expires, the Romanian government must formally confirm its intent to join EMBL as a full member state. The working group's evaluation reports provide the evidence base for this decision.

5.4.2. Legal and Treaty Steps

Prepare and deposit the instruments of accession to the EMBL Establishing Agreement:

- Government decision/decree approving accession.
- Parliamentary ratification if constitutionally required.
- Deposit of instrument of accession with the Swiss Federal Council (the depositary of the EMBL Agreement).
- Notification to EMBL Council.

5.4.3. Financial Transition

Upon full membership, Romania begins paying phased contributions:

Year of Membership	Est. % of Full Contribution	Est. Amount (€)	Status
Year 1 (2030)	~30%	~€600K–900K	First contribution
Year 2 (2031)	~45%	~€900K–1.35M	Increasing
Year 3 (2032)	~60%	~€1.2M–1.8M	Increasing
Year 4 (2033)	~80%	~€1.6M–2.4M	Approaching full
Year 5 (2034)	100%	~€2M–3M	Full contribution

> *These are indicative estimates based on public data from comparable member states. The exact contribution will be determined by the EMBL Council based on Romania's national income and the prevailing contribution scale at the time of accession.*

5.4.4. Full Integration

Romania's Council delegates gain full voting rights. Romania can propose EMBL scientific initiatives, host EMBL partnership nodes, and fully participate in all governance decisions.

6. Budget Analysis and Financial Considerations

6.1. Contribution Model

EMBL member state contributions are calculated based on a scale that reflects each country's national income (NNI — net national income). The contribution scale is adjusted periodically by the EMBL Council. For context, Denmark's contribution represents approximately 1.82% of total member state contributions, amounting to DKK 14.9 million (~€2 million) annually.

Switzerland's contribution to EMBC alone is approximately 3.69% of EMBC's annual budget of around €31 million. EMBC membership is a separate cost from EMBL membership but is generally much smaller.

6.2. Cost-Benefit Framing

The relevant comparison is not "is €2–3 million a lot?" but "what does Romania get for €2–3 million that it cannot get otherwise?" The answer includes:

- Institutional access to Europe's leading molecular biology research organization.
- Training pipeline: PhD and postdoctoral slots at EMBL for Romanian researchers.
- EMBO fellowships: short-term, long-term, installation grants for Romanian scientists.
- Infrastructure access: cryo-EM, synchrotron beamlines, bioinformatics compute, sequencing.
- Network effects: collaboration opportunities, joint grants, industry connections.
- Governance participation: voice in European life-science strategy.
- Signaling: Romania's credibility as a serious participant in European science.

For comparison, a single cryo-EM instrument costs €3–5 million to purchase and €500K+ annually to operate. Romania's EMBL contribution would buy institutional access to multiple such instruments plus everything else in the EMBL portfolio.

6.3. Fiscal Context

Romania's general government deficit peaked at approximately 9.3% of GDP in 2024, creating a constrained fiscal environment. This makes the case for phased entry even stronger: the three-year prospect period requires zero membership fees, and full membership contributions are themselves phased over approximately five years. The first real payment (~€600K–900K) would not occur until approximately 2030.

6.4. Potential Co-Funding and Leverage

EMBL membership costs could potentially be partially offset or leveraged through:

- Horizon Europe grants requiring member-state institutional partnerships.
- EMBO Installation Grants (up to €50,000/year for 3–5 years) supporting Romanian returnee scientists.
- Romanian national RDI budget allocations already earmarked for international research cooperation.
- Industry co-investment from Romanian pharma/biotech companies benefiting from EMBL access.

7. Working Group: Proposed Composition and Terms of Reference

7.1. Membership

Category	Suggested Representatives	Role
Ministry of Research	Director / Secretary of State; Department Head for International Cooperation	Chair; lead authority
Ministry of Foreign Affairs	Director for International Organizations or Treaty Affairs	Treaty logistics, accession instruments
Ministry of Finance	Budget planning officer for international contributions	Financial assessment
Romanian Academy	Vice-President for Life Sciences; Director of Institute of Biochemistry	Scientific authority and coordination
Major universities (life sciences)	Vice-Rectors or Deans from UB, UAIC Iași, UBB Cluj, UMF Carol Davila, UMFST Târgu Mureș	Institutional demand and support
Medical universities	Representatives from UMF Iași, UMF Cluj, UMF Timișoara	Health/clinical research demand
National R&D institutes	Directors or deputies from Victor Babeș, Cantacuzino, IRCBC	Research demand mapping
Romanian Bioinformatics Cluster (CRB)	CRB coordinator (currently legal rep: Prof. Claudia Banescu)	ELIXIR bridge; bioinformatics needs
RSBI	RSBI president or board member	Community mobilization
Biotech/pharma sector	1–2 industry representatives	Innovation and economic case
Romanian diaspora scientists at EMBL/EMBO	1–2 Romanian researchers currently active at EMBL or EMBO institutions	Insider perspective; network facilitation

7.2. Terms of Reference

The working group should operate with the following mandate:

5. Prepare and submit to the government a national position paper on EMBL and EMBC accession within 6 months.
6. Conduct the demand-mapping exercise and cost-benefit analysis.
7. Coordinate informal and formal engagement with EMBL and EMBC.
8. Draft all required documents (Statement of Intent, ministerial memoranda, parliamentary submissions).
9. Organize the Romanian Life Sciences Forum and other outreach events.
10. Produce annual progress reports during the prospect period.
11. Recommend to the government whether to proceed to full membership.

8. Key Documents: Templates and Guidance

This section provides template language and guidance for the principal documents required at each stage of the accession process.

8.1. Ministerial Memorandum (Decision in Principle)

Purpose: To obtain government-level approval to pursue EMBL Prospect Membership.

Addressee: Prime Minister / Cabinet / Government, with co-signature from Ministry of Research, Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Ministry of Finance.

Format: Follows the standard Romanian government memorandum (Nota de Fundamentare) structure.

> *Template language for the operative section:*

"Romania recognizes the strategic importance of advanced molecular biology and related life-science infrastructures for national scientific competitiveness, health innovation, and human capital development. In this context, Romania shall initiate the institutional, diplomatic, scientific, legal, and budgetary analyses required to evaluate and, where appropriate, pursue Prospect Membership in the European Molecular Biology Laboratory (EMBL), and in parallel shall pursue membership in the European Molecular Biology Conference (EMBC)."

The memorandum should include sections on: background on EMBL/EMBC, strategic rationale, estimated costs, proposed working group, timeline, and requested government action.

8.2. Statement of Intent for EMBL Prospect Membership

Purpose: The formal document by which Romania commits to pursuing EMBL membership, triggering the three-year prospect period.

Signatory: Minister of Research (or equivalent) on behalf of the Government of Romania.

Recipient: EMBL Director General and EMBL Council Chair.

> *Template language:*

"On behalf of the Government of Romania, I hereby confirm Romania's intention to pursue membership in the European Molecular Biology Laboratory (EMBL). Romania commits to accede to the Agreement Establishing the European Molecular Biology Laboratory within the framework of a three-year prospect membership period. Romania recognizes the value of EMBL's research, services, training, and integrating missions for Romanian life science, and looks forward to contributing to and benefiting from EMBL's activities as a prospect member state."

8.3. Letter of Intent to EMBC

Purpose: To formally initiate Romania's accession to EMBC.

Signatory: Minister of Research or Minister of Foreign Affairs.

Recipient: EMBC President and EMBO Director.

> *Template language:*

"The Government of Romania hereby expresses its intention to accede to the European Molecular Biology Conference (EMBC) by ratifying the EMBC Agreement. Romania is committed to strengthening

its participation in European life-science research and training, and recognizes the value of EMBO's programmes in supporting scientific mobility, excellence, and capacity building. Romania requests information on the accession procedures and stands ready to present its application to the EMBC at its earliest convenience."

8.4. Memorandum of Understanding (EMBL – Romanian Institution)

EMBL regularly signs MoUs with leading institutions in member and prospect member states. The MoU is a formal but non-binding framework for collaboration, exchange, and joint activities.

Typical MoU elements:

- Preamble acknowledging shared scientific interests and complementary strengths.
- Commitment to promote researcher exchange and mobility.
- Commitment to facilitate joint training activities.
- Commitment to open data sharing and use of shared technologies.
- Framework for joint research projects where mutual interest exists.
- Duration (typically 5 years, renewable).
- Signatures: EMBL Director General (or designee) and the head of the Romanian partner institution.

Recommended Romanian partner institutions for MoU: Romanian Academy Institute of Biochemistry, Romanian Bioinformatics Cluster (CRB), or a leading medical university with strong molecular biology programmes.

8.5. National Demand-Mapping Questionnaire

A template questionnaire for distribution to Romanian universities, Academy institutes, R&D institutes, and medical research centres. The questionnaire should collect:

12. Institution name and type.
13. Primary life-science research areas (molecular biology, genomics, bioinformatics, structural biology, imaging, computational biology, other).
14. Number of active research groups in relevant fields.
15. Current or past interactions with EMBL, EMBL-EBI, EMBO, or ELIXIR.
16. Estimated number of PhD candidates who would apply to EMBL annually.
17. Estimated number of postdocs who would apply to EMBL fellowships annually.
18. Interest in EMBL services (imaging, sequencing, structural biology, data resources).
19. Interest in EMBL/EMBO training courses and conferences.
20. Interest in institutional partnership or MoU with EMBL.
21. Other comments or needs.

8.6. Scientific Community Support Letter

A letter signed by 20–50 Romanian principal investigators, institute heads, and university leaders expressing support for Romania's EMBL and EMBC accession. The letter should be addressed to the Minister of Research and copied to the Prime Minister.

> *Template opening: "We, the undersigned Romanian scientists and research leaders, call upon the Government of Romania to pursue membership in the European Molecular Biology Laboratory (EMBL) and the European Molecular Biology Conference (EMBC). Romania's absence from these organizations represents a significant gap in our national research infrastructure. EMBL/EMBC membership would provide our researchers with access to world-class training, facilities, data resources, and collaboration networks that are currently available to scientists in 32 other European countries but not to us."*

9. Stakeholder Mapping and Engagement Strategy

9.1. Key Institutional Stakeholders

Stakeholder	Interest	Engagement Approach
Ministry of Research, Innovation and Digitalization	Lead authority for international research cooperation	Direct briefing; chair of working group
Ministry of Foreign Affairs	Treaty ratification; science diplomacy	Joint briefing with MoR; treaty logistics
Ministry of Finance	Budget implications	Cost-benefit note; phased commitment framing
Romanian Academy	Scientific legitimacy; institutional weight	Academy resolution supporting accession
Romanian Parliament	Ratification (if constitutionally required)	Legislative briefing; committee hearing
University rectors	Institutional access; training; prestige	Demand survey; forum invitations
Hospital research leaders	Clinical genomics; precision medicine	Health-oriented benefits narrative
CRB / RSBI	ELIXIR bridge; bioinformatics coordination	Direct integration into working group
Biotech/pharma industry	Innovation; talent pipeline; EMBL tech transfer	Industry roundtable; co-funding exploration
Romanian diaspora scientists	Network; advocacy; insider knowledge	Advisory role; reference letters; event speakers
EMBL International Relations	Institutional counterpart	Formal and informal meetings; visits
EMBC / EMBO	Parallel accession track	Formal accession request; delegation presentation
European Commission (DG R&I)	ERA integration; supportive context	Reference in narrative framing

9.2. Communication Strategy

Key messages for each audience:

- **Government/politicians:** EMBL is a concrete investment in Romania's scientific competitiveness, health innovation capacity, and European standing. All comparable EU countries are already members.
- **Scientists/researchers:** EMBL membership opens direct access to the best training, infrastructure, and collaboration networks in European molecular biology. Your applications to EMBL programmes will be on equal footing with researchers from 29+ member states.
- **Industry:** EMBL's technology transfer, corporate partnership programme, and talent pipeline offer concrete value for biotech and pharmaceutical companies operating in Romania.

- **Media/public:** Romania is joining Europe's top laboratory for life-science research — strengthening our capacity for medical breakthroughs, biotechnology innovation, and scientific excellence.

10. Risks and Mitigation Strategies

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
Budget constraint prevents commitment	Medium-High	High (blocks process)	Emphasize phased contributions; €0 during prospect period; first payment only ~€600K–900K in Year 4
Low national demand / underuse	Medium	Medium (weak ROI)	Demand mapping before commitment; targeted outreach to active groups
Political change disrupts multi-year process	Medium	High	Frame as bipartisan RDI infrastructure investment; anchor in national strategy documents
EMBC ratification delayed by parliamentary process	Low-Medium	Medium (delays full membership)	Start EMBC process early (Year 1); maintain parallel track
Coordination failure across ministries/institutions	Medium	Medium	Dedicated working group with clear mandate and chair
Insufficient absorptive capacity	Low-Medium	Medium (reduces value)	Build capacity through ELIXIR, EU projects, targeted master's/PhD programmes
EMBL rejects Romania or imposes conditions	Very Low	High	Unlikely given recent pattern of welcoming new members; maintain good diplomatic relations

11. Linkage with ELIXIR and Other European Research Infrastructures

Romania's EMBL accession should be framed as part of a broader national strategy for European research infrastructure integration, not as an isolated initiative.

11.1. ELIXIR → EMBL Pipeline

Romania's 2023 ELIXIR Observer status provides the most direct bridge to EMBL. ELIXIR is coordinated by EMBL-EBI, and many ELIXIR activities directly intersect with EMBL's services and training. The Romanian Bioinformatics Cluster (CRB), centred around 17 universities and research centres and coordinated with RSBI, already constitutes a functional national network for bioinformatics. This network can be leveraged for EMBL engagement.

The logical policy narrative is: ELIXIR Observer (2023) → ELIXIR Full Member → EMBC Member → EMBL Prospect Member → EMBL Full Member. Each step builds on the previous one.

11.2. Other Relevant Infrastructures

Romania should assess its participation (current or potential) in other ESFRI-roadmap research infrastructures that intersect with life sciences:

- BBMRI-ERIC (biobanking and biomolecular resources)
- Euro-BioImaging (biological and biomedical imaging)
- INSTRUCT-ERIC (structural biology)
- Infrafrontier (mouse models and phenotyping)
- EU-OPENSCREEN (chemical biology and screening)

EMBL membership would strengthen Romania's position in all of these related infrastructures by providing a home-base connection to the organization that often coordinates between them.

12. What Romanian Researchers Gain: A Programme-by-Programme Overview

Programme/Service	Description	Benefit for Romanian Researchers
EMBL International PhD Programme	Prestigious 4-year doctoral programme across all EMBL sites; University of Cambridge degree (for EMBL-EBI)	Top-tier training; international network; competitive advantage
EIPOD-LinC Postdoctoral Programme	Interdisciplinary postdoc with EMBL + member-state partner lab	Structured return pathway; dual supervision; member-state partnership
EMBL Advanced Training Courses	~100 courses/year in Heidelberg and other sites	Skills development; networking; methodology access
EMBL Imaging Centre	Cryo-EM, super-resolution, intravital microscopy	Access to €5M+ instruments without own investment
EMBL-EBI Data Resources & Bioinformatics	UniProt, Ensembl, ENA, PDBe, and many more	Enhanced bioinformatics capacity; ELIXIR synergy
Structural Biology (Hamburg/Grenoble)	X-ray beamlines, sample preparation, cryo-EM	Direct infrastructure access for structural biology projects
EMBL Corporate Partnership Programme	Industry networking, tech transfer, career events	Industry connections; biotech ecosystem access
EMBO Short-Term Fellowships (via EMBC)	Up to 3 months in another EMBC country lab	Mobility; technique learning; collaboration building
EMBO Long-Term Fellowships (via EMBC)	Up to 2 years postdoctoral in another country	International career development
EMBO Installation Grants (via EMBC)	€50,000/year for 3–5 years for returnee scientists	Talent retention; lab setup support for returnees

13. Governance and Monitoring Framework

13.1. Reporting Structure

The working group reports to the Minister of Research (or equivalent). Annual progress reports are submitted to the government and shared with the EMBL Council delegation.

13.2. Decision Gates

Gate	Decision	Timing
Gate 1	Government decision in principle to pursue EMBL/EMBC membership	Q2 2026
Gate 2	Authorization to sign Statement of Intent	Q4 2026 / Q1 2027
Gate 3	Annual prospect-period review (Years 2, 3)	Q4 2028, Q4 2029
Gate 4	Decision on full EMBL membership accession	Q1 2030
Gate 5	Parliamentary ratification (if required)	Q2 2030

13.3. Success Criteria for Full Membership Decision

The decision at Gate 4 should be evidence-based. Minimum criteria for recommending full membership:

22. At least 5 Romanian researchers actively engaged with EMBL programmes (PhD, postdoc, services).
23. At least 1 institutional MoU signed with EMBL.
24. At least 2 national events co-organized with EMBL.
25. Positive assessment of cost-benefit balance by the working group.
26. EMBC accession completed or in final stage.
27. Budget line for EMBL contributions secured in forward estimates.

14. Comprehensive Master Timeline

Period	Action	Responsible
Q1–Q2 2026	Draft ministerial memorandum; inter-ministerial consultation	Ministry of Research
Q2 2026	Government decision in principle	Cabinet
Q2 2026	Establish National Working Group	Ministry of Research
Q2–Q3 2026	Demand-mapping survey distributed and collected	Working Group
Q3 2026	Cost-benefit analysis completed	Working Group + Finance
Q3 2026	Begin EMBC accession process (contact EMBC/EMBO)	MFA + Research Ministry
Q3–Q4 2026	Informal engagement with EMBL (meetings, delegation visit)	Working Group
Q4 2026	EMBL Information Day in Romania (or early 2027)	Working Group + EMBL
Q1 2027	Scientific community support letter (20–50 signatures)	Working Group + CRB
Q1–Q2 2027	Minister signs Statement of Intent with EMBL	Minister of Research
Q2 2027	EMBL Council votes to admit Romania as Prospect Member	EMBL Council
Q2 2027	Romania designates Council delegates	Government
Q2–Q3 2027	Romanian Life Sciences Forum (co-organized with EMBL)	Working Group
Q3–Q4 2027	Institutional MoU signed (EMBL + Romanian institution)	Working Group + EMBL
Q4 2027	Press release and public communication	Government + EMBL
2027–2028	Complete EMBC ratification and accession	MFA + Parliament
2028	First annual prospect-period progress report	Working Group
2028	Romanian researchers apply to EMBL PhD, EIPOD, courses	Research community
2028	Second national event or themed workshop	Working Group
2029	Second annual progress report	Working Group
2029	TREC visit to Romania (if scheduling permits)	Working Group + EMBL
Q1 2030	Government confirms intent to join EMBL as full member	Cabinet
Q2 2030	Parliamentary ratification (if required)	Parliament
Q2–Q3 2030	Deposit instruments of accession with Switzerland	MFA
Q4 2030	Romania becomes EMBL full member state	EMBL Council
2030–2034	Phased contribution payments (30% → 100%)	Ministry of Finance

15. Annexes: Complete Document Templates

*This section contains **ready-to-use** template documents for every stage of Romania's accession process. Each annex is designed to be adapted, translated where necessary, and deployed with minimal additional drafting.*

Annex A: Complete Draft — Ministerial Memorandum (Nota de Fundamentare)

GUVERNUL ROMÂNIEI

NOTĂ DE FUNDAMENTARE

Titlu: Memorandum privind inițierea procesului de aderare a României la Laboratorul European de Biologie Moleculară (EMBL) și la Conferința Europeană de Biologie Moleculară (EMBC)

Inițiator: Ministerul Cercetării, Inovării și Digitalizării

Avize: Ministerul Afacerilor Externe; Ministerul Finanțelor

I. Context

Laboratorul European de Biologie Moleculară (EMBL) este o organizație interguvernamentală fondată în 1974, dedicată cercetării fundamentale în biologia moleculară, bioinformatică, biologia structurală și domenii conexe. EMBL operează în șase locații europene: Heidelberg (Germania), Barcelona (Spania), Grenoble (Franța), Hamburg (Germania), Hinxton/Cambridge (Anglia — Institutul European de Bioinformatică, EMBL-EBI) și Roma (Italia).

EMBL este susținut în prezent de 29 de state membre cu drepturi depline, un stat membru asociat (Australia) și două state cu statut de membru prospectiv (Serbia din 2023, Bulgaria din 2024). România nu este membră a EMBL.

Conferința Europeană de Biologie Moleculară (EMBC) este o organizație interguvernamentală distinctă, fondată în 1969, care finanțează programele Organizației Europene de Biologie Moleculară (EMBO). EMBC are în prezent 32 de state membre, incluzând toate țările vecine ale României (Bulgaria, Ungaria, Serbia prin EMBL). România nu este membră a EMBC.

România a devenit Observator ELIXIR în octombrie 2023, demonstrând angajamentul țării față de integrarea în infrastructurile europene de cercetare în științele vieții.

II. Motivație strategică

Aderarea la EMBL și EMBC ar consolida poziția României în cercetarea europeană în științele vieții prin:

- Acces la infrastructură de cercetare de varf (imagistică, biologie structurală, bioinformatică, secvențiere).
- Participare la programe de formare de excelență (programul doctoral internațional EMBL, burse postdoctorale EIPOD-LinC).
- Acces la bursele EMBO (burse pe termen scurt și lung, granturi de instalare pentru cercetători care revin în țară).
- Integrare în rețelele europene de cercetare în biologia moleculară și genomică.
- Reținerea și circulația talentelor științifice românești.
- Consolidarea capacității naționale în medicină de precizie, biotehnologie și inteligență artificială pentru biologie.

III. Mecanismul de aderare

EMBL oferă un mecanism de aderare graduală prin statutul de Membru Prospectiv (Prospect Membership):

- Perioada de membru prospectiv: 3 ani.
- Contribuție financiară în perioada prospectivă: zero.
- Acces complet la facilități, servicii, programe de formare, programe doctorale și postdoctorale.
- Participare ca observator în Consiliul EMBL (doi delegați: unul guvernamental, unul științific).
- La sfârșitul perioadei de 3 ani: decizie de aderare deplină, cu contribuții financiare fațazate (aprox. 30% în primul an, crescând la 100% în 5 ani).

IV. Implicații financiare

Contribuția anuală estimată la statutul de membru deplin EMBL, bazată pe comparații cu țări similare ca pondere în PIB-ul UE (Ungaria: ~€1,05M; Grecia: ~€1,5M; Portugalia: ~€1,6M; Polonia: ~€4,5M), se situează în intervalul €2–3 milioane/an. Această sumă devine exigibilă abia după finalizarea perioadei prospective (2030), cu o fațazare pe 5 ani.

Taxa unică de aderare este modestă (exemple recente: €45.000 pentru Estonia, €106.000 pentru Letonia).

Contribuția la EMBC se estimează separat, dar este semnificativ mai mică (bugetul total EMBC: ~€31 milioane/an).

V. Acțiuni propuse

28. Adoptarea unei decizii de principiu la nivel guvernamental privind inițierea procesului de aderare la EMBL și EMBC.
29. Mandatarea ministerului competenț să deschidă discuții exploratorii cu EMBL și EMBC.
30. Constituirea unui grup de lucru interinstituțional pentru pregătirea dosarului de aderare.
31. Elaborarea unui document de poziție națională în termen de 6 luni.
32. Inițierea procesului de ratificare a Acordului EMBC.

VI. Calendar estimativ

2026: Pregătire internă și decizia de principiu. 2027: Semnarea Declarației de Intenție și obținerea statutului de Membru Prospectiv EMBL. 2027–2029: Perioada prospectivă. 2030: Decizia de aderare deplină.

VII. Propunere de text al deciziei

„România recunoaște importanța strategică a biologiei moleculare avansate și a infrastructurilor conexe din științele vieții pentru competitivitatea științifică națională, inovația în sănătate și dezvoltarea capitalului uman. În acest context, România va iniția analizele instituționale, diplomatice, științifice, juridice și bugetare necesare pentru a evalua și, după caz, a urmări obținerea statutului de Membru Prospectiv în cadrul Laboratorului European de Biologie Moleculară (EMBL) și a statutului de membru al Conferinței Europene de Biologie Moleculară (EMBC).”

Ministrul Cercetării, Inovării și Digitalizării: [Nume, Semnătură]

Aviz Ministerul Afacerilor Externe: [Nume, Semnătură]

Aviz Ministerul Finanțelor: [Nume, Semnătură]

Annex B: Complete Draft — Statement of Intent for EMBL Prospect Membership

Bucharest, [Date]

To: The Director General of the European Molecular Biology Laboratory

Copy: The Chair of the EMBL Council

Subject: Statement of Intent of the Government of Romania Regarding Prospect Membership in the European Molecular Biology Laboratory

Dear Director General,

On behalf of the Government of Romania, I have the honour to communicate the following Statement of Intent.

Romania recognizes the European Molecular Biology Laboratory (EMBL) as the pre-eminent intergovernmental organization for molecular biology research, services, training, innovation, and integration of life sciences in Europe. Romania values EMBL's contributions to advancing fundamental knowledge in the life sciences and to strengthening European scientific competitiveness.

Romania has a strong and growing community of researchers in molecular biology, genomics, bioinformatics, computational biology, structural biology, medical research, and related disciplines. Romania is committed to deepening its integration into the European Research Area and to investing in the scientific capacity and talent development of its researchers.

In this context, the Government of Romania hereby formally communicates its intention to pursue membership in EMBL through the Prospect Membership mechanism. Romania commits to the following:

33. Romania intends to accede to the Agreement Establishing the European Molecular Biology Laboratory within the framework of a three-year prospect membership period, as provided for in EMBL's established procedures.
34. During the prospect membership period, Romania will designate two delegates to attend the EMBL Council as observers: one governmental representative from the Ministry of Research, Innovation and Digitalization, and one scientific representative to be identified in consultation with the Romanian scientific community.
35. Romania will pursue, in parallel, accession to the European Molecular Biology Conference (EMBC), and intends to complete the EMBC ratification process within the prospect membership period.
36. Romania will actively engage with EMBL's programmes, services, and training activities during the prospect period, and will encourage its researchers to participate in EMBL's PhD programme, postdoctoral fellowships, courses, and infrastructure services.
37. Romania will organize, in cooperation with EMBL, national outreach activities to maximize the benefits of the prospect membership for the Romanian research community.

Romania looks forward to a productive and mutually beneficial relationship with EMBL and to contributing to the advancement of European life sciences.

Respectfully,

[Name]

Minister of Research, Innovation and Digitalization

Government of Romania

Annex C: Complete Draft — Letter of Intent to EMBC

Bucharest, [Date]

To: The President of the European Molecular Biology Conference (EMBC)

Copy: The Director of the European Molecular Biology Organization (EMBO)

Subject: Expression of Intent by the Government of Romania to Accede to the European Molecular Biology Conference (EMBC)

Dear President,

The Government of Romania hereby expresses its intention to accede to the European Molecular Biology Conference (EMBC) by ratifying the EMBC Agreement.

Romania is committed to strengthening its participation in European life-science research and training, and recognizes the significant value of EMBO's programmes — including long-term and short-term fellowships, installation grants, young investigator awards, courses, and workshops — in supporting scientific mobility, excellence, and capacity building across Europe.

Romania's life-science research community has been growing steadily, with particular strengths in molecular biology, genomics, bioinformatics, medical research, and computational biology. Romanian institutions are increasingly engaged in European collaborative projects, and Romania has recently joined ELIXIR as an Observer (October 2023), demonstrating its commitment to European research infrastructure integration.

Romania requests information on the formal accession procedures for EMBC membership and stands ready to present its application to the EMBC at its earliest convenience. Romania intends to complete the necessary national legal steps, including government approval and any required parliamentary ratification, in a timely manner.

Romania believes that its membership in EMBC will benefit both the Romanian scientific community and the broader European life-science landscape, and looks forward to productive collaboration.

Respectfully,

[Name]

Minister of Research, Innovation and Digitalization

(or Minister of Foreign Affairs, as appropriate)

Government of Romania

Annex D: Complete Draft — Scientific Community Support Letter

[City], [Date]

To: The Minister of Research, Innovation and Digitalization

Copy: The Prime Minister of Romania; The President of the Romanian Academy

Subject: Open Letter from the Romanian Scientific Community in Support of Romania's Membership in the European Molecular Biology Laboratory (EMBL) and the European Molecular Biology Conference (EMBC)

Dear Minister,

We, the undersigned Romanian scientists, research leaders, university professors, institute directors, and members of the Romanian Academy, respectfully call upon the Government of Romania to pursue membership in the European Molecular Biology Laboratory (EMBL) and the European Molecular Biology Conference (EMBC).

Romania's absence from these organizations represents a significant and growing gap in our national research infrastructure. EMBL and EMBC membership would provide Romanian researchers with institutional access to:

- World-class research facilities in molecular biology, imaging, structural biology, and bioinformatics.
- EMBL's International PhD Programme — one of the most competitive and prestigious doctoral programmes in the life sciences globally.
- Postdoctoral fellowships and interdisciplinary research opportunities (EIPOD-LinC).
- EMBO's fellowship programmes (short-term, long-term, and installation grants supporting scientists returning to their home countries).
- Advanced training courses and conferences at the EMBL Advanced Training Centre in Heidelberg.
- Collaborative networks connecting thousands of researchers across 29+ European countries.
- Data resources, bioinformatics tools, and computational infrastructure at EMBL-EBI.

These opportunities are currently available to scientists in all of Romania's neighbouring countries — Bulgaria, Hungary, Serbia (as a prospect member), Poland, and others — but not to Romanian researchers. This disparity affects our ability to attract and retain talented young scientists, to compete for European funding, and to build the institutional partnerships that modern research demands.

Romania's life-science community has demonstrated its readiness for this step. We are active in European projects, we participate in ELIXIR (Observer since 2023), and our universities and institutes produce researchers who go on to work at leading institutions worldwide — including at EMBL itself. What we lack is the formal, institutional framework that membership provides.

We note that the financial commitment is modest relative to the benefits: zero cost during the three-year prospect membership period, followed by phased contributions starting at approximately €600,000–900,000 per year. For a country that spends billions on RDI, this is a highly efficient investment in scientific capacity and European integration.

We therefore urge the Government to:

38. Adopt a decision in principle to pursue EMBL Prospect Membership and EMBC membership.
39. Establish a national working group to prepare the accession dossier.
40. Engage formally with EMBL and EMBC at the earliest opportunity.

We stand ready to support this process in any way requested — as advisors, as members of the working group, as delegates, or as ambassadors for this initiative within the scientific community.

Respectfully,

SIGNATORIES

No.	Name and Title	Institution	Signature
1.	[Prof. Dr. _____, Rector/Director]	[University/Institute]	
2.	[Acad. _____, Member of the Romanian Academy]	[Section/Institute]	
3.	[Prof. Dr. _____, Dean/Department Head]	[University/Faculty]	
4.	[Dr. _____, Senior Researcher]	[R&D Institute]	
5.	[Prof. Dr. _____, Head of Research]	[Medical University/Hospital]	
...	[Continue to 20–50 signatories]		

Annex E: Complete National Demand-Mapping Questionnaire

Title: National Survey: Romania's Readiness for EMBL and EMBC Membership

Distributed by: National Working Group for EMBL/EMBC Accession

Distribution list: All Romanian universities with life-science, medical, or engineering faculties; Romanian Academy institutes in biology, biochemistry, medicine; National R&D institutes in biology, medicine, genomics; Hospital research units; Biotech/pharma companies with R&D operations in Romania.

Deadline: [4 weeks from distribution]

Return to: [Working Group Secretariat email]

SECTION 1: INSTITUTIONAL IDENTIFICATION

Q#	Question	Response Format
1.1	Institution name	Free text
1.2	Institution type	University / Medical university / Academy institute / R&D institute / Hospital / Biotech company / Other
1.3	City and county	Free text
1.4	Name and title of respondent	Free text
1.5	Contact email	Free text
1.6	Total number of researchers in life-science departments/units	Number

SECTION 2: RESEARCH AREAS

Q#	Question	Response Format
2.1	Primary research areas (select all that apply)	Molecular biology / Genomics / Bioinformatics / Computational biology / Structural biology / Imaging (microscopy) / Biochemistry / Cell biology / Developmental biology / Neurobiology / Microbiology / Virology / Immunology / Cancer biology / Precision medicine / AI for biology / Biotechnology / Other (specify)
2.2	Number of active research groups in the areas above	Number per area
2.3	Do you currently produce or analyze large-scale biological data (genomics, proteomics, imaging, etc.)?	Yes / No / Partially

2.4	Do you use bioinformatics tools or databases from EMBL-EBI (e.g., UniProt, Ensembl, ENA, PDBe)?	Yes, regularly / Yes, occasionally / No / Not sure

SECTION 3: EXISTING CONNECTIONS WITH EMBL/EMBO/ELIXIR

Q#	Question	Response Format
3.1	Does your institution have any current or past collaborations with EMBL, EMBL-EBI, or EMBO?	Yes (describe) / No
3.2	Are any of your current researchers EMBL alumni (former PhD students, postdocs, or staff)?	Yes (number and names) / No / Not sure
3.3	Have any of your researchers received EMBO fellowships?	Yes (number) / No / Not sure
3.4	Is your institution involved in ELIXIR activities (directly or through CRB/RSBI)?	Yes / No
3.5	Does your institution participate in any other European research infrastructure (ESFRI)?	Yes (list) / No

SECTION 4: INTEREST IN EMBL PROGRAMMES AND SERVICES

Q#	Question	Response Format
4.1	How many PhD candidates from your institution would realistically apply to the EMBL International PhD Programme annually?	0 / 1–2 / 3–5 / 6–10 / 10+
4.2	How many postdoctoral researchers would apply to EMBL postdoctoral programmes (EIPOD-LinC)?	0 / 1–2 / 3–5 / 5+
4.3	How many researchers would benefit from EMBO short-term fellowships (up to 3 months)?	0 / 1–3 / 4–10 / 10+
4.4	How many researchers would benefit from EMBO long-term fellowships (up to 2 years)?	0 / 1–2 / 3–5 / 5+
4.5	Would any early-career group leaders at your institution apply for EMBO Installation Grants?	Yes (how many) / No / Not sure
4.6	How many researchers would attend EMBL advanced training courses annually?	0 / 1–3 / 4–10 / 10+
4.7	Would your institution use EMBL Imaging Centre services (cryo-EM, super-resolution microscopy)?	Yes, definitely / Probably / Unlikely / Not applicable
4.8	Would your institution use EMBL structural biology beamlines (Hamburg/Grenoble)?	Yes, definitely / Probably / Unlikely / Not applicable

4.9	Would your institution be interested in a formal partnership or MoU with EMBL?	Yes / Possibly / No

SECTION 5: INSTITUTIONAL SUPPORT

Q#	Question	Response Format
5.1	Does your institution support Romania's pursuit of EMBL and EMBC membership?	Strongly support / Support / Neutral / Do not support
5.2	Would your institution be willing to sign a community support letter to the government?	Yes / No / Need more information
5.3	Would your institution be willing to participate in a national life-sciences forum co-organized with EMBL?	Yes / Possibly / No
5.4	Would your institution be willing to contribute to the National Working Group?	Yes (nominate representative) / No
5.5	Additional comments or suggestions regarding Romania's EMBL/EMBC accession	Free text

Annex F: Complete Draft — Template Memorandum of Understanding (EMBL – Romanian Institution)

MEMORANDUM OF UNDERSTANDING

between

THE EUROPEAN MOLECULAR BIOLOGY LABORATORY (EMBL)

and

[ROMANIAN PARTNER INSTITUTION]

PREAMBLE

The European Molecular Biology Laboratory (hereinafter "EMBL"), an intergovernmental organization established by the Agreement of 10 May 1973, with its headquarters in Heidelberg, Germany, represented by its Director General,

and

[Full legal name of the Romanian institution] (hereinafter "the Partner"), located in [City], Romania, represented by its [Rector / Director General / President],

hereinafter jointly referred to as "the Parties",

RECOGNIZING the mutual interest of the Parties in promoting excellence in molecular life-science research, training, and innovation;

ACKNOWLEDGING the complementary strengths and expertise of EMBL and the Partner in [relevant fields, e.g., bioinformatics, genomics, molecular medicine, structural biology];

DESIRING to establish a framework for enhanced collaboration, exchange, and mutual support;

NOTING that Romania is pursuing Prospect Membership in EMBL, reflecting its commitment to deeper integration into European life-science research;

HAVE REACHED THE FOLLOWING UNDERSTANDING:

Article 1 — Purpose

This Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) establishes a framework for collaboration between EMBL and the Partner, with the aim of promoting researcher exchange and mobility, facilitating joint training activities and scientific workshops, supporting open data sharing and the use of shared key technologies, enabling joint research projects in areas of mutual interest, and strengthening the circulation of scientific talent between EMBL and Romania.

Article 2 — Areas of Cooperation

The Parties intend to cooperate in the following areas, subject to the availability of resources and in accordance with their respective rules and regulations:

- Exchange of researchers, including short-term visits, sabbaticals, and secondments.
- Joint organization of scientific seminars, workshops, and training events.
- Collaboration on research projects of mutual interest, including joint grant applications.
- Facilitation of access by the Partner's researchers to EMBL facilities and services.

- Sharing of data, methodologies, and expertise in bioinformatics, imaging, genomics, and related fields.
- Joint supervision of PhD students and postdoctoral researchers where appropriate.
- Dissemination of scientific knowledge to the wider community, including public engagement activities.

Article 3 — Implementation

Each Party will designate a coordinator responsible for the implementation of this MoU. The coordinators will meet (in person or virtually) at least once annually to review progress, identify new opportunities, and plan activities for the following year. Specific collaborative activities may be governed by separate agreements or project plans as needed.

Article 4 — Financial Provisions

This MoU does not in itself create any financial obligations for either Party. The costs of specific collaborative activities will be agreed upon separately on a case-by-case basis, subject to the availability of funding and the respective rules and regulations of each Party.

Article 5 — Intellectual Property

Intellectual property arising from activities under this MoU will be governed by the relevant rules of each Party and, where applicable, by the terms of specific project agreements. The Parties agree to negotiate in good faith regarding the ownership, protection, and exploitation of any jointly developed intellectual property.

Article 6 — Duration and Termination

This MoU shall take effect upon signature by both Parties and shall remain in force for a period of five (5) years. It may be renewed by mutual written agreement. Either Party may terminate this MoU by giving six (6) months' written notice to the other Party. Termination shall not affect any ongoing collaborative activities, which shall be completed in accordance with their own terms.

Article 7 — Legal Status

This MoU is an expression of the Parties' shared intentions. It is not intended to be legally binding and does not create any legal rights or obligations under international, national, or any other law.

For EMBL:

Name: _____

Title: Director General (or designee)

Date: _____

Signature: _____

For [Romanian Partner Institution]:

Name: _____

Title: [Rector / Director General]

Date: _____

Signature: _____

Annex G: Budget Scenario Analysis

This annex presents three budget scenarios for Romania's EMBL and EMBC contributions over the 2026–2037 planning horizon.

Scenario 1: Conservative (Lower Bound — €2M Full Annual Contribution)

Year	EMBL Status	EMBL Fee	EMBC Fee (est.)	Total	Cumulative
2026	Preparation	€0	€0	€0	€0
2027	Prospect (Yr 1)	€0	~€80K	~€80K	~€80K
2028	Prospect (Yr 2)	€0	~€80K	~€80K	~€160K
2029	Prospect (Yr 3)	€0	~€80K	~€80K	~€240K
2030	Full Member (Yr 1)	~€600K	~€80K	~€680K	~€920K
2031	Full Member (Yr 2)	~€900K	~€80K	~€980K	~€1.9M
2032	Full Member (Yr 3)	~€1.2M	~€80K	~€1.28M	~€3.18M
2033	Full Member (Yr 4)	~€1.6M	~€80K	~€1.68M	~€4.86M
2034	Full Member (Yr 5+)	~€2.0M	~€80K	~€2.08M	~€6.94M

Scenario 2: Central Estimate (€2.5M Full Annual Contribution)

Year	EMBL Status	EMBL Fee	EMBC Fee (est.)	Total	Cumulative
2026	Preparation	€0	€0	€0	€0
2027	Prospect (Yr 1)	€0	~€80K	~€80K	~€80K
2028	Prospect (Yr 2)	€0	~€80K	~€80K	~€160K
2029	Prospect (Yr 3)	€0	~€80K	~€80K	~€240K
2030	Full Member (Yr 1)	~€750K	~€80K	~€830K	~€1.07M
2031	Full Member (Yr 2)	~€1.13M	~€80K	~€1.21M	~€2.28M
2032	Full Member (Yr 3)	~€1.50M	~€80K	~€1.58M	~€3.86M
2033	Full Member (Yr 4)	~€2.00M	~€80K	~€2.08M	~€5.94M

2034	Full Member (Yr 5+)	~€2.50M	~€80K	~€2.58M	~€8.52M

Scenario 3: Upper Bound (€3M Full Annual Contribution)

Year	EMBL Status	EMBL Fee	EMBC Fee (est.)	Total	Cumulative
2026	Preparation	€0	€0	€0	€0
2027	Prospect (Yr 1)	€0	~€80K	~€80K	~€80K
2028	Prospect (Yr 2)	€0	~€80K	~€80K	~€160K
2029	Prospect (Yr 3)	€0	~€80K	~€80K	~€240K
2030	Full Member (Yr 1)	~€900K	~€80K	~€980K	~€1.22M
2031	Full Member (Yr 2)	~€1.35M	~€80K	~€1.43M	~€2.65M
2032	Full Member (Yr 3)	~€1.80M	~€80K	~€1.88M	~€4.53M
2033	Full Member (Yr 4)	~€2.40M	~€80K	~€2.48M	~€7.01M
2034	Full Member (Yr 5+)	~€3.00M	~€80K	~€3.08M	~€10.09M

> *Notes: (1) EMBC annual fee estimated at ~€80K based on Romania's likely share of the EMBC budget of ~€31M. (2) EMBL phasing assumes 30%/45%/60%/80%/100% over 5 years, consistent with reported past practice. (3) One-time accession fee for EMBL not included; expected to be in the €50K–150K range based on recent precedents. (4) All figures are indicative estimates subject to EMBL Council determination of the applicable contribution scale.*

Annex H: Draft Press Release — Romania Becomes EMBL Prospect Member

PRESS RELEASE

EMBARGOED UNTIL: [Date and Time]

Romania becomes EMBL prospect member state

Starts three-year process toward full membership, opening new opportunities for scientific exchange and collaboration

Bucharest / Heidelberg, [Date] — Romania has become the latest prospect member state of the European Molecular Biology Laboratory (EMBL), starting a three-year process toward full membership. The prospect membership opens new opportunities for scientific exchange and collaboration between EMBL and Romania.

Romania's Minister of Research, Innovation and Digitalization, [Name], signed the formal Statement of Intent on behalf of the Romanian Government. "Romania is committed to strengthening its life-science research capability and its integration into the European Research Area," the Minister said. "Our membership will benefit both Romania's scientific community and EMBL, and we look forward to contributing to European excellence in molecular biology."

The EMBL Director General welcomed Romania's decision: "We are delighted to welcome Romania as a prospect member state. Romania has a growing community of talented life scientists, and we look forward to deepening our collaboration and supporting Romanian researchers through EMBL's facilities, training, and professional network."

During the prospect membership phase, Romania's delegation will attend EMBL's governing Council as observers. Romanian researchers will gain full access to EMBL's services, training programmes, and facilities, including the EMBL International PhD Programme, postdoctoral fellowships, the EMBL Imaging Centre, structural biology beamlines, and EMBL-EBI's world-leading bioinformatics data resources.

Romania is pursuing EMBL membership as part of a broader strategy to deepen its participation in European research infrastructures. Romania became an ELIXIR Observer in 2023 and is also pursuing membership in the European Molecular Biology Conference (EMBC).

Including Romania, EMBL is now supported by [XX] full member states, one associate member state, and [XX] prospect member states.

About EMBL

The European Molecular Biology Laboratory (EMBL) is Europe's leading intergovernmental organization for molecular biology research, with laboratories at six sites across Europe. EMBL's missions include research, services, training, innovation, and integration of European life sciences. For more information: www.embl.org

Media contacts:

[Romanian Ministry of Research press office: name, email, phone]

[EMBL Press Office: press@embl.org]

Annex I: Draft Agenda — Romanian Life Sciences Forum

Title: First Romanian Life Sciences Forum: Romania and EMBL — Building a Partnership

Proposed date: [Q3 2027, after formal prospect membership]

Proposed venue: Romanian Academy / University of Bucharest / Carol Davila Medical University / Other (to be confirmed)

Format: One-day in-person event with virtual option

Target audience: Romanian researchers in life sciences, genomics, bioinformatics, structural biology, imaging, molecular medicine; ministry officials; industry representatives

PROGRAMME

Time	Session	Speakers
09:00–09:30	Registration and coffee	
09:30–09:45	Opening remarks: Romania's path to EMBL membership	Minister of Research / Secretary of State
09:45–10:00	Welcome from EMBL	EMBL Director General or representative
10:00–10:30	Keynote: EMBL's missions and what membership means for national science	EMBL Senior Scientist / International Relations
10:30–11:00	EMBL International PhD Programme and postdoctoral opportunities	EMBL PhD Programme Manager
11:00–11:30	Coffee break and networking	
11:30–12:00	EMBL-EBI: bioinformatics data resources and collaboration opportunities	EMBL-EBI representative
12:00–12:30	EMBL Imaging Centre and structural biology services	EMBL Imaging / Structural Biology representative
12:30–13:00	EMBO programmes: fellowships, installation grants, and career support	EMBO representative
13:00–14:00	Lunch and poster session	Romanian researchers present their work
14:00–14:30	Romania's ELIXIR engagement: from bioinformatics to EMBL	CRB/RSBI coordinator
14:30–15:30	Roundtable: Romanian research groups and their connections to EMBL's research themes	3–4 Romanian PIs (genomics, structural biology, computational biology, medical research)
15:30–16:00	Coffee break	
16:00–16:45	Panel discussion: How to maximize Romania's EMBL membership	Ministry, EMBL, Romanian Academy, industry

16:45–17:00	Closing remarks and next steps	Working Group Chair
17:00–18:00	Networking reception	

Logistics note: EMBL has a proven format for national information days (used in Latvia, September 2023; Estonia; and others). The EMBL International Relations team can advise on programme structure, speaker availability, and co-branding. Budget for the event should cover: venue, catering, travel for 2–4 EMBL speakers, poster boards, and a modest communication budget. Estimated cost: €10,000–€25,000 depending on venue and scale.

Annex J: Key Contacts and Resources Directory

Organization	Contact Point / URL	Purpose
EMBL International Relations	https://www.embl.org/about/member-states/	Prospect membership process; exploratory meetings
EMBL Director General's Office	https://www.embl.org/about/	Statement of Intent recipient
EMBL Council Secretariat	https://www.embl.org/about/info/embl-council/	Council meeting logistics; observer status
EMBC / EMBO	https://embc.embo.org/members-and-partners/	EMBC accession process
EMBO Director	https://www.embo.org/	EMBC accession; EMBO programmes
EMBL International PhD Programme	https://www.embl.org/about/info/embl-international-phd-programme/	PhD recruitment information
EMBL EIPOD-LinC Postdoc Programme	https://www.embl.org/about/info/postdoctoral-programme/	Postdoctoral opportunities
EMBL Imaging Centre	https://www.embl.org/about/info/imaging-centre/	Cryo-EM and microscopy access
EMBL-EBI	https://www.ebi.ac.uk/	Bioinformatics services and collaboration
EMBL Institutional Collaborations	https://www.embl.org/partnerships/	MoU and partnership frameworks
EMBL Corporate Partnership	https://www.embl.org/about/info/support/embl-corporate-partnership-programme/	Industry engagement
EMBL Documents Repository	https://www.embl.org/documents/	Establishing Agreement; annual reports
ELIXIR Europe	https://elixir-europe.org/	ELIXIR membership coordination
ELIXIR Romania / CRB / RSBI	https://rsbi.ro/resurse/elixir/	National bioinformatics coordination
Romania Min. of Research	https://www.research.gov.ro/	Lead national authority
Swiss Federal Council (Depositary)	Federal Dept. of Foreign Affairs, Bern	EMBL instrument of accession deposit

Annex K: EMBL and EMBC Member States (Current as of March 2026)

EMBL Member States

Full members (29): Austria, Belgium, Croatia, Czech Republic, Denmark, Estonia, Finland, France, Germany, Greece, Hungary, Iceland, Ireland, Israel, Italy, Latvia, Lithuania, Luxembourg, Malta, Montenegro, Netherlands, Norway, Poland, Portugal, Slovakia, Spain, Sweden, Switzerland, United Kingdom.

Associate member (1): Australia.

Prospect members (2): Serbia (since June 2023), Bulgaria (since July 2024).

Notable non-members: Romania, Cyprus, Slovenia, Türkiye.

EMBC Member States

Members (32): Austria, Belgium, Bulgaria, Croatia, Czech Republic, Denmark, Estonia, Finland, France, Germany, Greece, Hungary, Iceland, Ireland, Israel, Italy, Latvia, Lithuania, Luxembourg, Malta, Montenegro, Netherlands, Norway, Poland, Portugal, Slovakia, Slovenia, Spain, Sweden, Switzerland, Türkiye, United Kingdom.

Not members: Romania is not an EMBC member state. Romania is one of the few remaining EU member states outside EMBC.

Comparative Table: Romania's Neighbours

Country	EMBL Member?	EMBC Member?	ELIXIR Member?	Year Joined EMBL
Romania	NO	NO	Observer (2023)	—
Bulgaria	Prospect (2024)	Yes (2024)	Yes	2024 (prospect)
Hungary	Yes	Yes	Yes	2017
Poland	Yes	Yes	Yes	2019
Czech Republic	Yes	Yes	Yes	2014
Slovakia	Yes	Yes	Yes	2018
Croatia	Yes	Yes	Observer	2006
Serbia	Prospect (2023)	No	Yes	2023 (prospect)
Slovenia	No	Yes	Yes	—
Türkiye	No	Yes	Yes	—

> *Romania's position is unique among larger EU member states: it is the only EU country with a population exceeding 15 million that belongs to neither EMBL nor EMBC. This anomaly weakens Romania's standing in European life-science policy and deprives its researchers of access to programmes enjoyed by their peers in all neighbouring countries.*

Annex L: Checklist — Complete Accession Milestones

This checklist tracks all required milestones from initiation to full membership. It can be used by the Working Group as a progress-tracking tool.

#	Milestone	Target Date	Responsible	Status
1	Ministerial memorandum drafted	Q1 2026	Min. of Research	□
2	Inter-ministerial clearance obtained	Q2 2026	MoR / MFA / MoF	□
3	Government decision in principle adopted	Q2 2026	Cabinet	□
4	National Working Group established	Q2 2026	Min. of Research	□
5	Demand-mapping questionnaire distributed	Q2 2026	Working Group	□
6	Demand-mapping results compiled	Q3 2026	Working Group	□
7	Cost-benefit analysis completed	Q3 2026	WG + Finance	□
8	EMBC contacted (letter of intent sent)	Q3 2026	MFA + MoR	□
9	EMBL contacted (exploratory meeting requested)	Q3 2026	Working Group	□
10	Romanian delegation visits EMBL site	Q4 2026	Working Group	□
11	EMBL Information Day in Romania (or early 2027)	Q4 2026 / Q1 2027	WG + EMBL	□
12	Scientific community support letter signed (20-50 names)	Q1 2027	WG + CRB/RSBI	□
13	Statement of Intent signed by Minister	Q1–Q2 2027	Minister of Research	□
14	EMBL Council votes to admit Romania as Prospect Member	Q2 2027	EMBL Council	□
15	Two Council delegates designated	Q2 2027	Government	□
16	Romanian Life Sciences Forum organized	Q2–Q3 2027	Working Group	□
17	MoU signed (EMBL + Romanian institution)	Q3–Q4 2027	WG + EMBL	□
18	Press release and public communication	Q4 2027	Govt + EMBL	□
19	EMBC ratification: government approval obtained	2027–2028	MFA + Cabinet	□
20	EMBC ratification: parliamentary action (if needed)	2027–2028	Parliament	□
21	EMBC: instrument of ratification deposited	2028	MFA	□
22	EMBC: delegation presents at EMBC meeting	2028	Delegates	□
23	First annual prospect-period progress report	Q4 2028	Working Group	□
24	Romanian researchers actively applying to EMBL programmes	2028+	Research community	□

25	Second national event or workshop co-organized with EMBL	2028–2029	Working Group	□
26	Second annual progress report	Q4 2029	Working Group	□
27	Government confirms intent to join EMBL as full member	Q1 2030	Cabinet	□
28	Parliamentary ratification of EMBL Agreement (if required)	Q2 2030	Parliament	□
29	Instrument of accession deposited with Switzerland	Q2–Q3 2030	MFA	□
30	Romania admitted as EMBL full member state	Q3–Q4 2030	EMBL Council	□
31	First phased EMBL contribution paid	2030	Min. of Finance	□
32	Full contributions reached (100%)	~2034	Min. of Finance	□

16. Conclusion and Recommended Immediate Actions

Romania has a clear, achievable path to EMBL membership within 4 years. The Prospect Membership mechanism provides a low-risk, zero-cost entry point that allows Romania to test demand, build engagement, and demonstrate value before committing to full membership. Recent successful accessions by Serbia, Bulgaria, Latvia, and Estonia provide proven templates to follow.

The core constraints are political will and budget. The political case is strong: Romania is the only large EU member state absent from EMBL and EMBC, and all neighbouring countries are members. The budget case is manageable: the prospect period is free, and full contributions are phased over five years starting at approximately €600,000–900,000 per year.

Recommended immediate actions:

41. **Within 30 days:** Brief the Minister of Research on this plan and request authorization to proceed with the ministerial memorandum.
42. **Within 60 days:** Draft and circulate the ministerial memorandum for inter-ministerial consultation.
43. **Within 90 days:** Establish the National Working Group and begin the demand-mapping exercise.
44. **Within 120 days:** Send an informal request to EMBL International Relations for an exploratory meeting.
45. **Within 180 days:** Complete the cost-benefit analysis and submit the national position paper to the government.

— END OF DOCUMENT —